The only way to keep on top of everything is to address any issue as soon as it arises; nothing can be left until later because a backlog quickly develops and things never get done.

If a bowler shows too much emotion on the field, and gets upset because someone has misfielded or dropped a catch, I will immediately go across and tell him he needs to control himself; if anybody lets their head drop or appears to disagree with a decision, I will very quickly pull them back into line.

Off the field, if anyone is late for a meeting or late for the bus or messing around during practice, I will speak to him straight away and let him know his behaviour is unacceptable. Working with the coach and Dr Moosajee, we try to maintain our standards and culture.

I also make a point of trying to check each member of the squad at least once each and every day; if I can look an individual straight in the eye, and see he is focused and present, then I'm happy.

All this sounds like hard work, but it's also hugely rewarding when a plan goes well and the team plays to its potential, or when a player responds to something you say and performs. The only element of the captain's job that sounds like hard work – and is never anything less than hard work – is speaking to the media. I realise it needs to be done, and I always try to be open and honest, but it is not something I ever enjoy.

Leaders eat last. I read that somewhere and the concept of standing back still appeals to me because, even though I enjoy the captaincy, my preference remains to perform as well as I can and then, without anyone noticing, to slip away while others soak up the limelight. Since I was a boy, I have never wanted to be the face of anything. The team should always be the face.

So, trailing 0–1 in the series with two Tests still to play, we arrived at the Wanderers Stadium. I won my first toss as captain, decided we would bat first and worked hard to keep everyone positive.

Our first-innings total of 313 might have seemed a decent start